Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A J 10 8 3
♥ A 3
♦ A J 7
♣ A Q 5

♠ Q 2
♥ K 9 5 2
♦ Q 8 5 4
♣ 10 6 4



♠ 5
♥ Q J 10 8 7
♦ 9 6 2
♣ J 9 7 3

♠ K 9 7 6 4
♥ 6 4
♦ K 10 3
♣ K 8 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	Pass	3♠
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

6♠ by North
Lead: ♥Q

South's 3♠ bid is a limit raise showing 10-12 points and good trump support. North is to play 6♠. East leads the ♥Q.

This ♦ holding is the first example shown in the introduction.

With one certain ♥ loser you cannot afford to lose a ♦ also. You could guess which way to finesse and be correct half of the time. But an elimination play will work ALL of the time.

Win the first trick and play ♠A, ♠K. Trumps split 2-1.

Next play three rounds of ♣s to eliminate that suit from both your and dummy's hand.

With all the eliminations completed you are in your hand.

The throw-in: a ♥ from either hand. One of the defenders wins (you don't care which), and is end-played.

The defender who won the last trick cannot lead a trump because he has none. If he leads a ♥ or a ♣ you will get a ruff-sluff, ruffing in one hand while discarding a ♦ loser from the other. If he leads a ♦ you will get the free finesse you were hoping for all along.

If you finesse West for the ♦Q you make the contract, but if you finesse East for that card you go down.

With an elimination play you make it no matter who holds the Queen.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 5 ♥ K 9 8 5 2 ♦ A 10 8 ♣ 10 9 6 3	
♠ K 9 7 6 4 ♥ 6 4 ♦ J 7 3 ♣ Q 8 2	N W E S	♠ A J 10 8 3 ♥ A 3 ♦ Q 5 2 ♣ A K 5
	♠ Q 2 ♥ Q J 10 7 ♦ K 9 6 4 ♣ J 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♠	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♥Q

East is to play 4♠. South leads the ♥Q.

This ♦ holding is the second example shown in the introduction.

This should remind you a lot of Deal 1. This time you have 1 ♥ loser and 3 ♦ losers. If you can force the opponents to lead ♦s you can make a trick with the ♦Q or ♦J, avoiding one of those losers.

Win the first trick and play ♠A, ♠K. Trumps split 2-1.

Next play three rounds of ♣s to eliminate that suit from you and dummy.

The eliminations are complete and you are in your hand.

It is time for the throw-in: the small ♥, taken by one of the defenders.

No matter which defender wins the ♥ he is end-played. A ♥ or a ♣ will give you a ruff-sluff, but if he leads a ♦ you cannot be prevented from establishing either your ♦Q or ♦J as a winner.

If you try to make a ♦ trick on your own you will fail. The first defender will play "second-hand-low" and the other defender will take your ♦Q (or ♦J).

Only by forcing them to start the ♦s can you take a trick in the suit.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ K 9 7 6 4
♥ 6 4
♦ K 10 3
♣ K 8 2

♠ Q 2
♥ Q J 10 7
♦ Q 8 6 4
♣ J 7 4



♠ 5
♥ K 9 8 5 2
♦ J 5 2
♣ 10 9 6 3

♠ A J 10 8 3
♥ A 3
♦ A 9 7
♣ A Q 5

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♠
Pass	3♠	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

6♠ by South
Lead: ♥Q

South is to play 6♠. West leads the ♥Q.

This ♦ holding is the third example shown in the introduction.

This is another follow-up to Deal 1. But this time you are missing both the ♦Q and ♦J. In this case an Elimination play doesn't give you a guarantee, it just improves your odds.

Win the first trick and play ♠A, ♠K. Trumps split 2-1.

Play three rounds of ♣s to eliminate the suit from you and dummy.

You are in your hand.

You execute the throw-in by leading a ♥.

The defender who gets thrown in cannot play a ♥ or a ♣ without handing you the contract by way of a ruff-and-sluff. So he must lead a ♦. Suppose it is West who leads the ♦. You play low in dummy and East must play either the ♦Q or ♦J to keep you from getting a cheap trick with your ♦9. So you take East's honor with your ♦A and then finesse West for the other honor. As long as the ♦Q and ♦J are in different hands the elimination play will succeed.

Against good defenders there is no way you can make all three ♦ tricks if you make the first play in the suit. This assumes that if one defender held both the ♦Q and ♦J he would "split" the honors if you tried to lead through them.

By forcing them to start the ♦s you make three tricks when the two outstanding honors are divided.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K J 4 ♥ 10 5 ♦ J 10 9 3 2 ♣ Q 7 4	
♠ 8 6 5 ♥ A Q 9 7 3 ♦ K 6 ♣ A J 5		♠ 9 7 3 ♥ K J 8 2 ♦ A 8 4 ♣ K 10 3
	♠ A Q 10 2 ♥ 6 4 ♦ Q 7 5 ♣ 9 8 6 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♥	Pass	3♥	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			

4♥ by West
Lead: ♦J

West is to play 4♥. North leads the ♦J.

With three unavoidable ♠ losers you cannot afford to lose a ♣. So you either have to guess the location of the♣Q or (DRUMROLL) pull off an elimination play! Win the ♦K, then pull trumps, it takes two rounds.

Next you eliminate the ♦s by playing ♦A then ruffing the ♦8.

You execute the throw-in by leading a ♠.

The defense is in with a ♠ and they are welcome to take two more ♠s. But then they will to have to play a ♠ or a ♦, giving you a ruff-sluff, or else lead a ♣ which finds the ♣Q for you.

Using elimination plays makes you a better player. But in Bridge, no matter how skillful you are, there will always be a luck factor.

Here you were lucky the defense didn't start by taking their three ♠s. If they had, you would not have been able to pull off the throw-in, and would have had to try your luck with guessing who had the ♣Q.

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A Q 8 7 5 2 ♥ 10 4 ♦ 9 3 ♣ A 6 2	
♠ 10 ♥ K J 8 3 2 ♦ A 5 4 2 ♣ 9 7 4	N W E S	♠ J 3 ♥ A 9 6 5 ♦ J 10 8 7 ♣ Q 8 5
	♠ K 9 6 4 ♥ Q 7 ♦ K Q 6 ♣ K J 10 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	1♠	Pass	2♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♦J

North is to play 4♠. East leads the ♦J, covered by the ♦Q and ♦A. West returns a ♦ to the ♦K.

You still have two losers in the ♥ suit, so the question is which way you plan to finesse the ♣s. And of course the answer is that you don't plan to finesse them at all!

Pull trumps with the ♠A, then ♠K. Next ruff dummy's last ♦.

You exit with a ♥. The defenders win this and take another ♥ trick, leaving this position.

They must now break the ♣ suit for you or give you a ruff-sluff. Of course you would ruff in dummy and discard a ♣ from the 3-card holding in your hand.

If West is the one who has to play a ♣ you just let it ride around to dummy's ♣ K J 10 3.

If East is the one who has to play a ♣ you need to insert the ♣10 or ♣J from dummy.

In either case you will no longer have a ♣ loser.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ Q J 9 ♥ Q 10 7 6 ♦ 10 5 2 ♣ 9 6 4	
♠ 10 6 4 3 2 ♥ K 5 2 ♦ K 8 ♣ K 10 2	N W E S	♠ A K 8 7 5 ♥ A 4 ♦ A 6 3 ♣ A J 7
	♠ — ♥ J 9 8 3 ♦ Q J 9 7 4 ♣ Q 8 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♠	Pass
3♠	Pass	6♠	
All Pass			

6♠ by East
Lead: ♦Q

West decides a limit raise is better than just jumping to game. East has heard enough and bids the slam.

East is to play 6♠. South leads the ♦Q.

Your first thought is probably that if you can guess the ♣Q you will make all thirteen tricks.

So you win the ♦K and play a ♠ to your ♠K. When South discards a ♦ your second thought is probably that you **MUST** guess the ♣Q just to make twelve tricks.

Hopefully your third thought is that if you use an elimination play you won't have to guess.

Play your ♠A, leaving North with the master ♠Q. Then eliminate ♦s by playing ♦A and ruffing a ♦ in dummy.

Now eliminate ♥s by playing ♥A, ♥K, and ruffing a ♥.

You are ready for the throw-in.

A ♠ to North's ♠Q.

North has just taken the defender's first trick. First and only. Because if he now plays a red card you will ruff in one hand and discard a losing ♣ from the other. And if he plays a ♣ you will no longer have a ♣ loser.

Most elimination plays work on the same principle. The biggest difference is usually the technique you have to use to complete the eliminations.

Here it took two ruffs, one in each hand.

Board 7
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 3 ♥ K Q 10 8 2 ♦ K 9 5 ♣ K 10 2	
♠ K Q 9 4 2 ♥ 5 ♦ Q 8 2 ♣ 9 6 5 3	N W E S	♠ A 7 6 ♥ 9 7 3 ♦ 10 6 4 3 ♣ Q 8 7
	♠ J 10 5 ♥ A J 6 4 ♦ A J 7 ♣ A J 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♦	Pass	2♥
Pass	3NT	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♠K

North first transfers you to ♥s, then gives you a choice of which game to play. Knowing you have an 9-card trump fit, you choose 4♥.

South is to play 4♥. The defenders start with ♠K, ♠Q, ♠A.

In addition to the two ♠s already lost you have a potential loser in each minor suit. On the plus side, you have a finesse position in ♦s and a two-way finesse in ♣s. If you work both finesses successfully you make an overtrick - if both fail you will be down 1. Or, you could try for a 100% sure end-play.

Ruff the ♠A with dummy's ♥10 and pull trumps (three rounds).

You cash the ♦K and ♦A.

You eliminate ♦s with the ♦K, ♦A and ♦J. If you are REALLY lucky the ♦Q will fall doubleton, but more than likely a defender will win the third ♦. He won't be happy about it, though.

Whichever defender wins the ♦Q is end-played. If he plays a ♦ or a ♠ you will ruff in one hand and discard a ♣ loser from the other. But if he leads a ♣ instead you no longer have a ♣ loser.

On this Deal an elimination play will guarantee that you make your contract.

However, it also guarantees that you will not make an overtrick.

If you try the two finesses instead you **MIGHT** make an overtrick, but you also might go down 1.

Decide for yourself!

Board 8
East Deals
None Vul

	♠ Q J 10 5 3 ♥ Q 8 7 2 ♦ 3 ♣ J 8 5	
♠ 8 6 2 ♥ J 3 ♦ J 10 6 5 ♣ 7 6 4 3	N W E S	♠ A ♥ A K 6 ♦ A K Q 9 7 4 ♣ A Q 9
	♠ K 9 7 4 ♥ 10 9 5 4 ♦ 8 2 ♣ K 10 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2♣	Pass
2♦	Pass	3♦	Pass
4♦	Pass	6♦	
All Pass			

6♦ by West
Lead: ♠Q

You naturally respond 2♦ to East's strong 2♣ opener. Before you know it you are playing a slam - with your mighty 2-point hand! West plays 6♦. North leads the ♠Q.

If the contract appears to depend upon a finesse, try to find another way. Here, you can always try the ♣ finesse, but maybe you can eliminate ♠s and see what happens.

Win the ♠A, play the ♦4 to the ♦10, and ruff a ♠ with the ♦Q. Both opponents followed to the trump.

Play the ♦7 to the ♦J and ruff the last ♠ with the ♦K.

Having eliminated the ♦s and ♠s, now remove the ♥s. Play ♥A, ♥K, and ruff a ♥.

At last it is time to play ♣s.

North plays low.

A ♣ from your hand, playing dummy's ♣9 when North plays low. South will win the trick but will be end-played, forced to either play a ♣ back to dummy's ♣ A Q, or give you a ruff-sluff.

If North puts on either the ♣10 or ♣J you play dummy's ♣Q. If South can win with the ♣K he will once again be end-played, forced to either play a ♣ back to dummy's ♣A 9, or give you a ruff-sluff.

The A Q 9 combination is interesting. Obviously if you have A Q 10 it works very well in an end-play situation.

As you see, A Q 9 actually works just as well.

Board 9
South Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ K 10 2 ♥ K Q 9 8 2 ♦ 8 5 4 ♣ A 3	
♠ J 7 5 ♥ 10 5 4 ♦ K 9 3 ♣ Q 9 8 5		♠ A 8 6 3 ♥ 7 ♦ Q J 10 6 ♣ J 10 7 2
	♠ Q 9 4 ♥ A J 6 3 ♦ A 7 2 ♣ K 6 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	1♥	Pass	2♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♦Q

North is to play 4♥. East leads the ♦Q.

You have two ♦ losers that you can't escape, as well as the ♠A. So you must arrange your play so you don't lose a trick to the ♠J. That could mean you will finesse one defender for that card, but it would be a lot better if you could make the defense play ♠s first.

There is no reason to hold up so take your ♦A and pull trumps, West showing up with three of them.

Now eliminate ♣s by playing ♣A, ♣K, and ruffing a ♣.

The stage is now set for the throw-in.

Be **SURE** to lead a ♦ for the throw-in, not a ♠.

The defense will win the ♦ and can then take another ♦ trick if they like. But then they will have to play a ♠ (or give you a ruff-sluff). And as long as they start the ♠s you are assured that you will lose only one ♠ trick, the ♠A.

Assume East is on lead for the first ♠ play.

If he leads the ♠A it sets up both the ♠K and ♠Q so you only have one ♠ loser. If he leads low you also play low from dummy and West must play the ♠J to prevent you getting a trick with the ♠10. Again you only lose one ♠.

If West makes the first play by leading a low ♠ you play low from your hand. East must go up with the ♠A to stop you from getting a trick with dummy's ♠9. Then your ♠K and ♠Q will win two tricks.

Board 10
North Deals
Both Vul

♠ Q 9 6 4 3
♥ 9 7 6 2
♦ 9 2
♣ 8 6

♠ K 7 2
♥ 5 3
♦ K Q J 6 5
♣ 10 7 5



♠ A J
♥ A
♦ A 10 8 7 4 3
♣ A J 9 3

♠ 10 8 5
♥ K Q J 10 8 4
♦ —
♣ K Q 4 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	Pass	1♦	1♥
2♥	Dbl	6♦	
All Pass			

6♦ by East
Lead: ♥K

West's 2♥ bid showed a hand with limit raise or better in ♦s. East doesn't bother with Blackwood since he already knows about the Aces. He just bids the slam. East plays 6♦. South leads the ♥K, won by you with the ♥A.

The good news is that you have no losers in ♠s, ♥, or ♦s. The bad news is that you have two losers in ♣s. The good news is that missing the ♣ K Q you could try two finesses. The bad news is that South overcalled, so he probably has both honors. The best news of all is that you know how to pull off an elimination play!. Play a trump to dummy's ♦K (South discards a ♥) and ruff the ♥5.

Pull the outstanding trump with the ♦A, then play ♠A, ♠K and ruff a ♠.

You want to play the first ♣ from dummy.

You enter dummy with a trump.

Dummy leads the ♣10 and North plays low.

Play the ♣10 from dummy and let it ride if North does not produce the ♣Q or ♣K. South will win with one of the honors but will have to return another ♣ or give you a ruff-sluff.

When you are missing the K Q of a suit, as in the ♣s on this hand, taking two finesses gives you a 75% chance of success - **all things being equal**.

In this case though, South's overcall means all things are not equal, so your chances are lower than 75%.

But never mind the percentages for a finesse, the end-play was a sure thing.

Board 11
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 9 3 2 ♥ A J 7 ♦ A 4 ♣ Q J 8 7 3	
♠ Q J 10 8 7 ♥ 6 5 4 ♦ Q J 3 ♣ K 4	N W E S	♠ A 6 5 ♥ Q 9 8 2 ♦ 10 8 7 6 2 ♣ 5
	♠ K 4 ♥ K 10 3 ♦ K 9 5 ♣ A 10 9 6 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
1♠	2♠	Pass	3♣
Pass	5♣		
All Pass			

5♣ by South
Lead: ♠Q

North's cue-bid shows a limit raise or better (11 points) in ♣s. South is to play 5♣. West leads the ♠Q, East takes the ♠A and returns the ♠6 to your ♠K.

You have lost one trick already and have a possible loser in trumps and another possible loser in ♥s. Both loserscan be avoided with successful finesses. The problem with the ♣ finesse is that West made an overcall so he is more likely to hold the ♣K. If you don't try the ♣ finesse you may be able to throw a defender in with the ♣K at a time when he will have to help you with his next play.

After winning the ♠K immediately play the ♣A.

It would have been nice to see the ♣K fall, but it didn't. So play a small ♦ to dummy's ♦A and play the ♠9, ruffing in your hand.

Eliminate the ♦s by playing ♦K, then ruffing your last ♦ in dummy.

You have done all the eliminating, time to throw in somebody.

You play a ♣ to throw West in.

Whichever defender had the ♣K is now on lead, but wishes he wasn't. If he plays a ♥ you get a free finesse. If he plays anything else you get a ruff-sluff.

If you had finessed for the ♣K West would have won the trick and been able to make a safe exit, probably with his other ♣.

You would then have been forced to rely on the ♥ finesse, and with West being the defender who showed some strength, you would likely have finessed through him.

About the only way the elimination/throw-in could fail is if the ♣s split 3-0. Then, if you play Ace and another the defender who wins would use his third ♣ as a safe exit.

Board 12
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K Q 10 3 ♥ 2 ♦ 10 8 7 2 ♣ K J 5 4	
♠ 5 ♥ K Q J 7 5 4 3 ♦ Q 5 ♣ A Q 10	N W E S	♠ A 8 6 2 ♥ A 10 9 6 ♦ A K ♣ 7 6 3
	♠ J 9 7 4 ♥ 8 ♦ J 9 6 4 3 ♣ 9 8 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	Pass	1NT	Pass
3♥	Pass	4♥	Pass
5♣	Pass	6♥	
All Pass			

6♥ by West
Lead: ♠K

Your 3♥ bid is a slam suggestion. After you show the ♣A partner wastes no time in bidding it.

West is to play 6♥. North leads the ♠K.

This is a good slam. You have only two possible ♣ losers, and by taking two ♣ finesses you have an excellent chance of success. But by using an elimination play you will have a sure thing.

Win the ♠A and ruff a ♠ with a ♥ honor.

Play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥9 and ruff another ♠. Both defenders followed to the trump play.

Play another ♥ to dummy's ♥10 and ruff the last ♠.

Play the ♦A and ♦K.

Conveniently you are in dummy.

South plays low.

You play a ♣ from dummy and insert the ♣10 when South plays low.

North will probably win this trick. If he wins with the ♣K then your hand is good. If he wins with the ♣J then he is end-played, forced to either lead a ♣ into your ♣ A Q or to give you a ruff-sluff.

You probably noticed that you could have finessed your ♣Q on the first ♣ play and pulled off the end-play just as effectively. But there is an advantage to making the first finesse with the ♣10.

If South just happens to hold both the ♣K and ♣J you will make all thirteen tricks if your first finesse is with the ♣10!

Board 13
North Deals
Both Vul

	♠ A 9 6 ♥ A Q 10 ♦ Q 8 4 ♣ K J 7 5	
♠ 8 5 4 3 ♥ J 4 3 ♦ J 10 9 ♣ 9 6 2		♠ K Q 2 ♥ K 9 7 2 ♦ K 7 5 3 ♣ 10 3
	♠ J 10 7 ♥ 8 6 5 ♦ A 6 2 ♣ A Q 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥2

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥2. West plays the ♥J which you win with the ♥Q.

You have one trick already in the bag, four more to come in ♣s, and three other Aces. So all you have to do it get one of those finesse positions to come through. By now, though, you must have figured that nothing is going to work! Even your best shot, West holding at least one of ♠ K Q will not happen. The answer (again) is to eliminate, then throw in.

This time there is only one suit you can eliminate, ♣s. So play all four ♣s, ending in dummy. They split 3-2.

West plays low.

You play the ♠J from dummy and let it ride when West follows with a low card. (If West had covered you would win the Ace then set up a second trick in the suit.)East wins with the ♠Q, and guess what?

HE IS ENDPLAYED!. He has no ♣s, and whichever other suit he plays will give you your ninth trick!

Wow! End-played at trick #6.

Board 14
East Deals
None Vul

	♠ 9 4 ♥ Q 7 5 3 2 ♦ A 9 3 ♣ 8 6 3	
♠ A 10 7 2 ♥ 9 6 ♦ J 5 4 ♣ Q J 9 5		♠ K J 6 5 ♥ A K ♦ Q 8 7 ♣ A K 7 4
	♠ Q 8 3 ♥ J 10 8 4 ♦ K 10 6 2 ♣ 10 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	Pass
3♣	Pass	3♠	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♥J

East is to play 4♠ after West's Stayman bid uncovered the 4-4 fit. South leads the ♥J which you win the your ♥A.

With three possible losers in ♦s you might first think that you will have to finesse one of the defenders for the trump Queen. But anytime you see an unsupported Jack opposite an unsupported Queen you should start thinking about a throw-in play. And what better card to use for the throw-in than the Queen of trumps.

So pull two rounds of trumps with the ♠A and ♠K, hoping the ♠Q falls. She doesn't fall, but both defenders do follow suit. So the ♠Q is the only trump outstanding.

Next eliminate ♥s from you and dummy by playing the ♥K.

Now play four rounds of ♣s to eliminate that suit. If a defender decides to ruff one of these ♣s with the master trump he will be end-played, forced to either play a ♦ or to give you a ruff-sluff. So assume that all four ♣s win tricks.

Now you administer the coup de grace.

You lead a trump.

One of the defenders has won the ♠Q. Too bad for him. If he now plays a ♦ you will make either the ♦Q or ♦J. If he plays a ♥ you will ruff in one hand and discard a ♦ loser from the other.

It is clear that the elimination play saved you having to guess the finesse for the ♠Q.

But what if you considered yourself a really good guesser? So good that you felt confident in taking the finesse, and so good that you pulled it off successfully.

You'd be no better off. Although you would avoid the ♠ loser you would now have to play the ♦s for yourself and you would lose three ♦s!

Board 15
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ Q 5 ♥ A J 6 2 ♦ A 9 6 4 ♣ A J 5	
♠ J 10 9 7 2 ♥ K 10 7 4 ♦ Q 8 2 ♣ 7	N W E S	♠ K 8 6 3 ♥ Q 9 8 3 ♦ 10 7 5 ♣ 8 2
	♠ A 4 ♥ 5 ♦ K J 3 ♣ K Q 10 9 6 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	4♣	Pass	6♣
All Pass			

6♣ by South
Lead: ♠J

South considered Blackwood, then realized if North showed either 2 or 3 Aces he was going to bid slam. But if North showed just one Ace he would have to maneuver to play 5NT which might be worse than 6♣. So he just bid the slam. South plays 6♣. West leads the ♠J.

You wish, you hope, you may even pray, but when you play the ♠Q East covers with the ♠K. So you know you have a ♠ loser. And unless East holds the ♦Q you might have a ♦ loser also.

Perhaps an elimination play will improve your chances. Don't lead a trump yet though, you're going to need several entries to dummy to eliminate the ♥s.

Win the ♠, play to the ♥A and ruff a ♥.

Play a trump to dummy's ♣J (both defenders follow)

and ruff another ♥ high.

Play to dummy's ♣A, pulling their last trump, and ruff the last ♥.

You execute the throw-in by leading a ♠. If West wins the trick he will have to play ♦s for you or give you a ruff-sluff. So if these are competent defenders they will make sure that it is **EAST** who wins the ♠ trick. So he does, and he plays a small ♦.

East leads a small ♦.

DO NOT PLAY THE JACK! If the finesse is going to work now it will still work one trick later. By playing low you take advantage of the possibility that East held the ♦10 and West will have to put on the ♦Q to prevent you taking a trick with dummy's ♦9.

Many elimination endings give you a sure thing. Others just improve your chances.

Here you had two chances. First, West might have HAD to win the throw-in, either because he had all of the high ♠s, or more likely because he messed up. The second chance paid off when East took the throw-in but you found a fortunate position with the ♦s.

Board 16
West Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ 9 6 5 ♥ 9 8 4 3 ♦ K Q 10 5 2 ♣ 6	
♠ K J 8 ♥ A J 5 ♦ A 3 ♣ A J 10 7 2	N W E S	♠ A 10 7 2 ♥ K Q ♦ 9 8 4 ♣ K Q 8 4
	♠ Q 4 3 ♥ 10 7 6 2 ♦ J 7 6 ♣ 9 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♣	Pass	1♠	Pass
2NT	Pass	4♣	Pass
6♣			
All Pass			

6♣ by West
Lead: ♦Q

The slam was easy to bid, now you just have to make it. West plays 6♣. North leads the ♦Q.

You have one certain ♦ loser, and a two-way finesse for the ♠Q. That should make you start thinking about elimination and throw-in. So win the ♦A and pull trumps, North having a singleton.

You eliminate the ♥s: the ♥K, the ♥Q overtaken by your ♥A, then the ♥J.

BE CAREFUL! On the ♥J you must discard a ♦ from dummy so both of you will be out of ♦s at the throw-in.

NOW you can execute the throw-in. Play your ♦, which eliminates ♦s from both you and dummy and at the same time throws in one of the defenders. Whoever it is will be forced to lead a ♠ and eliminate your guess for the ♠Q or else give you a ruff-sluff, allowing you to ruff in dummy and discard a ♠ loser from your hand.

Among Bridge players you often hear about someone (usually Aunt Harriet) who is amazingly lucky at guessing the location of missing Queens.

Perhaps Aunt Harriet isn't that lucky after all, perhaps she just knows how to perform elimination plays.

Hopefully in the future you will be the one with the reputation!

Board 17
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A K 8 6 2 ♥ 10 5 ♦ 4 3 2 ♣ A 8 5	
♠ — ♥ 9 6 ♦ K Q J 10 8 7 ♣ Q J 9 7 2	N W E S	♠ Q J 9 ♥ K Q J 8 7 4 2 ♦ 9 ♣ 10 4
	♠ 10 7 5 4 3 ♥ A 3 ♦ A 6 5 ♣ K 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	4♥	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♥K

When the bidding gets high in a hurry you sometimes have to guess what you can make. North plays 4♠. East leads the ♥K.

And it looks like you are too high. Assuming the trumps split 2-1, you still have one ♥ loser, two ♦ losers and one ♣ loser.

You win the ♥A and play a ♠ to your ♠K. West discards a ♦!

From bad to worse. Now you must add a ♠ loser to the four you already had. Are you finished?

No, never give up. East has a bunch of ♥s and 3 ♠s, so he cannot have many ♦s and ♣s. If you can eliminate those and then throw him in it should work to your advantage.

Play your ♠A, the ♦A and the ♣ A K. East follows to everything.

You've done all you can do. Now play the ♥10 to East's high ♥.

East has just won his side's first trick with the ♥J. He now plays the ♠Q, winning his side's second trick.

Now, East is still on lead, and he has nothing in his hand but good ♥s.

So he leads the ♥Q.

You **DO NOT RUFF**. Instead you discard a ♣ from dummy and a ♦ from your hand. East has now taken his side's third trick. He plays another good ♥, and you ruff in dummy and discard the last ♦ loser from your hand. You can now cross-ruff for the rest of the tricks.

Incredible isn't it.

You just wonder how many bridge players would have just conceded down 2 on this hand.

Not you or me, of course.

Board 18
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 8 5 ♥ J 10 9 6 ♦ 9 8 7 4 ♣ J 9 2	
♠ A 10 9 3 ♥ 7 5 4 ♦ A J 6 ♣ Q 7 5	N W E S	♠ K Q J 7 4 2 ♥ A Q 3 ♦ 5 ♣ A K 3
	♠ 6 ♥ K 8 2 ♦ K Q 10 3 2 ♣ 10 8 6 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	Pass	1♠	Pass
3♠	Pass	4NT[1]	Pass
5♥[2]	Pass	6♠	
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by East
Lead: ♦K

West's 3♠ is a limit raise, 11-12 points in support of ♠s. When you discover that the raise includes two Aces you bid the slam. East plays 6♠. South leads the ♦K, won by you with dummy's ♦A.

Is this a really easy elimination play showing up this late in the group? Or are you just getting better at seeing them? In any case, you should see that a successful ♥ finesse will land your contract, but you should also remember that there aren't many finesses working on these 25 deals.

So rather than finesse, eliminate! Pull trumps in two rounds, ending in dummy.

Ruff the ♦6, then play ♣A, ♣K, ♣Q.

So here you are in dummy. Do you finesse the ♥ now?

North plays low.

Of course not. You play the ♦J and discard a small ♥ from your hand. South wins his ♦Q (which his opening lead told you he held) and is end-played. He must lead a ♥ to your tenace or give you a ruff-sluff.

The answer to the question posed above is:

It is a pretty simple problem, but you are no doubt getting a lot better.

Board 19
West Deals
None Vul

♠ A 8 5 3
♥ Q 7 4
♦ 9 7 6 2
♣ 8 3

♠ Q 9 7 4
♥ 6
♦ A Q 8
♣ K Q J 7 5



♠ J 10 2
♥ 9 8 3
♦ J 10 4
♣ 9 6 4 2

♠ K 6
♥ A K J 10 5 2
♦ K 5 3
♣ A 10

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♣	Pass	Pass	Dbl
Pass	1♠	Pass	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♣K

North realizes that to make a takeout double, then jump in your own suit you must have a very good hand. So he bids the game. South plays 4♥. West leads the ♣K, which you take with the ♣A.

You have four losers. If you are thinking about leading toward your ♦K you are delusionary. West has the ♦A and you know it. Your best hope is to end-play West with the ♣10 and force him to break the ♦s.

Play one round of trumps with the ♥A. You can't play any more because you will need an entry to dummy for the elimination.

Next play ♠K, ♠A and ruff a ♠ high.

Lead a ♥ to dummy's ♥Q. West shows out. Play dummy's last ♠. East is now void, so if he ruffs you over-ruff. Otherwise you ruff with a small trump.

You are back in your hand.

Now throw West in (you hope!) with the ♣10.

Fortunately West has to take the ♣10. Since he has nothing left but ♣s and ♦s he must lead one or the other. A ♦ lead will give you a trick with your ♦K and a ♣ lead will allow you to ruff in dummy (East still has a ♣) and discard a ♦ from your hand.

Some problems are tougher than others, this being a tough one.

It was not a complete elimination since East still had a trump when you threw West in. However, it worked because West was out of both ♠s and ♥s.

Board 20
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 4 ♥ K J 9 5 ♦ Q J 10 4 ♣ Q 10 9 2	
♠ A K Q 6 3 2 ♥ A 6 3 ♦ 7 ♣ 7 6 4	N W E S	♠ J 10 9 7 5 ♥ 7 ♦ K 8 6 3 ♣ K 5 3
	♠ 8 ♥ Q 10 8 4 2 ♦ A 9 5 2 ♣ A J 8	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♠	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by West
Lead: ♦Q

West is to play 4♠. North leads the ♦Q.

South plays the ♦2 and you the ♦7.

North continues with the ♦J.

South plays low and you ruff with the ♠Q.

Unless North is real beginner South will hold the ♦A so you should not try the ♦K on this trick. And when North continues with the ♦J you should again duck in dummy, ruffing with an honor in your hand.

The contract is in danger if South holds the ♣A because you would have three ♣ losers to go with the ♦ already lost. One really good possibility is that South now has the lone ♦A and you can set up dummy's ♦K with a ruff.

So play a small ♠ to dummy's ♠9, (pulling the two outstanding trumps), and ruff another ♦ with an honor, hoping the ♦A drops.

Too bad, the ♦A did not fall so dummy's ♦K is not a winner. But it will still prove to be useful.

Play the ♥A, then ruff a ♥ in dummy. Play a trump to your ♠A and ruff your last ♥.

You are in dummy, just where you want to be.

South plays the ♦A.

Play the ♦K, and when South plays the ♦A don't ruff but instead discard a ♣ from your hand. You knew all along that he held the ♦A.

South is end-played, forced to either break the ♣s and give you a ♣ trick, or give you a ruff-sluff.

This was the toughest hand so far and the end-play depended upon your correct reading that South must hold the ♦A.

It also depended upon the defenders not switching to ♣s at the second trick. If North had decided to switch to the ♣Q you would have had no chance at all.

Board 21
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A J ♥ A Q 10 9 4 3 ♦ J ♣ A J 9 4	
♠ K 9 4 3 ♥ 8 5 ♦ 10 8 5 3 2 ♣ 7 6		♠ Q 10 8 5 2 ♥ 6 ♦ Q 9 7 ♣ K Q 5 2
	♠ 7 6 ♥ K J 7 2 ♦ A K 6 4 ♣ 10 8 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	Pass	3♥
Pass	6♥		
All Pass			

6♥ by North
Lead: ♠5

After hearing a limit raise, North's leap to 6♥ is, well, bold let's say. North plays 6♥. East leads the ♠5, dummy plays the ♠6 and West the ♠K.

Dummy wins the ♦K.

Dummy leads the ♦A and West follows.

Very bold in fact. The opening lead has exposed a ♠ loser in addition to your two ♣ losers. On the plus side dummy has an extra ♦ trick. You are going to have to try to throw East in with the ♣ suit, but you will have to be very careful with dummy's entries.

Win the ♠A, play the ♦J to dummy's ♦K and discard the ♠J on dummy's ♦A.

You are in dummy, so ruff the ♠7 with a high trump. Next play the ♥9 to dummy's ♥J. Both defenders follow, whew!

Back in dummy, ruff a ♦ with the ♥Q, then lead the ♥10 to dummy's ♥K, pulling the last trump as you enter dummy.

It would be great if you could ruff dummy's last ♦, then get back to dummy with a trump so you could lead a ♣ from dummy and finesse. But check your trumps. If you do that you will have no more trumps in your hand and East won't be endplayed because you have no ruff-sluff. The only thing you can do is to go ahead and play ♣s now, finessing into East and HOPING he has no more ♦s!

You were lucky, East had only three ♦s so your partial elimination worked.

But if it had turned out that East DID have another ♦, and led it, all would not be lost. You would ruff in your hand, play a trump to dummy, then take a second ♣ finesse. If it turned out the ♣K and ♣Q were in different hands you would make the slam.

Board 22
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ — ♥ 8 7 4 3 2 ♦ 9 6 4 3 ♣ 10 9 8 7	
♠ A 7 2 ♥ K Q J ♦ 7 5 2 ♣ K J 6 2		♠ Q 9 4 ♥ A 9 6 ♦ A K Q ♣ A Q 5 4
	♠ K J 10 8 6 5 3 ♥ 10 5 ♦ J 10 8 ♣ 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	3♠
6NT			
All Pass			

6NT by East
Lead: ♦J

Some bidding, huh? Well, what would you have bid in the West seat? East plays 6NT. South leads the ♦J.

Mirror distributions! So you can only make ten tricks in ♥s, ♦s and ♣s.

That means you will have to make two ♠ tricks. And since the odds are 5000 to 1 that South has the ♠K, leading toward your ♠Q is NOT your play.

Win the ♦ and play 4 rounds of ♣s. South follows to the first, then discards 3 ♠s.

Next play 3 ♥ winners. South follows twice, then discards a ♠.

Now play your 2 ♦ winners. North and South both follow.

Keeping your fingers crossed that South must win the next trick,

South puts on the ♠10.

North (thankfully) discards a ♥.

South has been thrown in and he has nothing left but the ♠ K J. Whichever one he plays you will take the last two tricks.

South no doubt thought his 3♠ bid was a good idea.

In fact, it just kept you from making a losing play, (leading toward the ♠Q), and allowed you to find the end-play to make the slam.

Board 23
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 7 3 2 ♥ Q J 8 6 ♦ A 5 4 3 ♣ A 9	
♠ 6 ♥ 9 4 3 ♦ J 10 9 6 ♣ Q 10 8 3 2	N W E S	♠ A Q J 10 9 4 ♥ 7 2 ♦ Q 8 ♣ J 6 5
	♠ K 8 5 ♥ A K 10 5 ♦ K 7 2 ♣ K 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	2♠	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♠6

South is to play 4♥. West leads the ♠6, taken by East with the ♠A. East returns the ♠Q, you play the ♠K and West ruffs. West next leads the ♦J.

After that unfortunate start you seem to be in a bit of trouble. Two tricks are already in the defender's pockets and you still have a ♠ loser and a ♦ loser. So you win with your ♦K and play two rounds of trumps.

The good news is that West started with three trumps, and since he already used one it only takes two pulls to pick up the remaining trumps.

Eliminate ♣s by playing ♣A, ♣K, and ruffing a ♣. Both defenders follow to all three ♣s.

So far East has followed suit to every trick, meaning he has not discarded a single ♠. Since you know he started with 6 ♠s, his final 5 cards consist of 4 ♠s and one other. You play to the ♦A and East follows suit again.

Dummy's ♠7: East wins, but he has nothing left but ♠s. When he plays another ♠ you discard your ♦ loser and ruff in dummy.

This is called a Partial Elimination because all of the ♦s were not eliminated.

However, the key is that you could tell they were eliminated from the East hand, and East was going to be the throw-in target because of his long ♠s.

In many hands an opponent who opens with a preemptive bid gives you the information you need to plan and execute the throw-in.

Board 24
West Deals
None Vul

	♠ 7 ♥ K 9 7 3 ♦ K 9 6 3 ♣ K 10 5 2	
♠ K Q 10 2 ♥ A Q 6 4 ♦ Q 7 ♣ Q J 4	N W E S	♠ A J 9 6 5 3 ♥ 5 2 ♦ A 2 ♣ 8 7 6
	♠ 8 4 ♥ J 10 8 ♦ J 10 8 5 4 ♣ A 9 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♥	Pass
2♠	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by West
Lead: ♣2

East first transfers you to ♠s, then closes the auction with 4♠.

West is to play 4♠. North leads the ♣2. South takes the ♣A and returns the ♣9 to North's ♣K. North plays another ♣ to your ♣Q.

With two tricks lost already you have a sure ♦ loser (unless the defenders goof) and a ♥ loser that might be taken care of if South holds the ♥K. But what if North holds the ♥K? Maybe an elimination play.

First pull trumps - they split 2-1.

Next eliminate ♦s by playing ♦A then another ♦. This does the elimination and throw-in at the same time.

If the defender who won the ♦K plays a ♦ or a ♣ you will ruff in your hand and discard dummy's ♥ loser. So that defender is going to have to lead a ♥.

If it is North who won the ♦K you are home free. His ♥ play will give you two ♥ tricks.

If it is South who won the ♦K you still have a chance. He will lead a ♥ and you will finesse the ♥Q.

In other words, played this way you make the contract whenever North holds the ♦K **OR** South holds the ♥K.

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With the cards as shown the elimination play works.

But if the ♦K is with South and the ♥K with North it wouldn't.

Of course it is POSSIBLE that if you played a low ♦ from dummy some Easts would duck and let you win a trick with your ♦Q.

This trickery would fail if North held the ♦K, or if South held it and went up right away.

Board 25
West Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ 4 3 ♥ A 7 ♦ 7 5 3 ♣ A Q J 9 6 3	
♠ K J 10 9 7 6 ♥ K 10 3 ♦ Q 8 2 ♣ 4	N W E S	♠ 8 ♥ Q J 9 8 5 4 2 ♦ 10 9 4 ♣ 5 2
	♠ A Q 5 2 ♥ 6 ♦ A K J 6 ♣ K 10 8 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2♠	3♣	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♥[2]	Pass	6♣
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♣ by North
Lead: ♠8

dummy's ♠Q.

A fairly complex elimination play to finish off the set.

I hope you enjoyed them.

North plays 6♣. East leads the ♠8.

You have one ♠ loser and one ♦ loser. A successful finesse will take care of either one of them. Chance of the ♠ finesse working? Zero. Chance of the ♦ finesse working? Maybe 50%. Chance of an elimination play? Priceless.

Win the ♠A and pull trumps with the ♣A and ♣Q. They split 2-1.

Play the ♦A, just in case there is a singleton ♦Q somewhere. There isn't. Then eliminate ♥s by playing ♥A and ruff a ♥.

A low ♠ from both hands. East doesn't follow suit as West wins with a small card.

West is end-played. He has no ♣s. If he plays a ♦ it will be into dummy's ♦ K J. If he plays a ♥ you will discard a ♦ from your hand and ruff in dummy. If he plays the ♠K you will ruff, and dummy's ♠Q will be promoted. If he plays a small ♠ you will let it ride to